

# Seawall height in Fort Lauderdale

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

FORT LAUDERDALE • BROWARD COUNTY

# 5.0

ft NAVD88, capped at BFE or 6.0

Fort Lauderdale sets both ends. The minimum is 5 ft NAVD88 and the maximum is your base flood elevation or 6 ft NAVD88, whichever is lower - and where those two rules collide, the minimum wins. The city also runs a waiver nobody mentions, which expires the day you sell. The barrier is designed against tidal flooding through the year 2070.

## The detail

|                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MINIMUM                                 | 5 ft NAVD88 for a new or modified tidal flood barrier. ULDR 47-19.13.D(1).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| MAXIMUM                                 | The base flood elevation on the FEMA FIRM, or 6 ft NAVD88, whichever is lower. In an X zone the cap is the natural ground elevation. Where the maximum would conflict with the 5 ft minimum, the minimum governs. ULDR 47-19.13.D(12).                                                                                                   |
| THE 2035 ROUTE                          | An application before 1 January 2035 may be permitted at 4 ft NAVD88, provided the barrier is designed to accommodate 5 ft NAVD88 by 1 January 2050. ULDR 47-19.13.D(1).                                                                                                                                                                 |
| THE WAIVER MOST PEOPLE NEVER HEAR ABOUT | If the principal structure has a habitable finished floor below 4.0 ft NAVD88, the city engineer may waive the minimum. It runs three years at most, it becomes void the moment the property changes hands, and the city can rescind it on fifteen days' notice if the wall is overtopped or fails to perform. The request fee is \$186. |
| THE 3.9 FIGURE IS DEAD                  | Before 23 March 2023 the minimum was 3.9 ft NAVD88 for properties with a base flood elevation of 4.0 ft, with a 5.0 ft maximum. Ordinance C-23-05 deleted it. Many existing walls were built to it, so an older wall that met code when it went in can now sit below the current minimum.                                                |
| WHAT COUNTS AS SUBSTANTIAL              | Either test triggers it - work along more than 50% of the shoreline length, or work exceeding 50% of the fair market replacement cost of the existing structure. Note it is replacement cost of the structure, not property value. ULDR 47-19.13.C(12).                                                                                  |
| THE TRAP IN THAT DEFINITION             | Docks, finger piers, piles and ancillary footers are excluded from the calculation - but a concrete dock poured monolithically with the seawall cap is counted in.                                                                                                                                                                       |

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| THE WHOLE SHORELINE                    | A barrier undergoing substantial repair must be built along the property's entire shoreline. ULDR 47-19.13.D(7). To the extent practicable it must also adjoin the neighbours' barriers to close gaps. D(6).                                                                                                                                                              |
| THE CLOCK, AND IT IS A CITABLE OFFENCE | 60 days to show progress after a citation, 365 days to complete. Letting tidal water trespass onto a neighbour or the right-of-way is declared a public nuisance. A wall built to the standard that is simply overtopped is not. ULDR 47-19.13.D(2) and (3).                                                                                                              |
| WHAT IT COSTS TO IGNORE                | Up to \$500 per violation, and each day a violation continues is a separate offence. Code of Ordinances Sec. 1-6(c). The city may also repair a seawall itself and place a lien for the cost. Sec. 2-155(2).                                                                                                                                                              |
| RIPRAP ON NEW WALLS                    | A vertical seawall built in marine waters where none existed before must carry natural limerock riprap, or approved habitat enhancement, at the waterward face. ULDR 47-19.13.D(8). Riprap on its own does not count as a barrier. C(13).                                                                                                                                 |
| CAPS                                   | A cap added to an existing wall must be at least as wide as the existing cap. D(5).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| YOUR DOCK FOLLOWS THE WALL             | On a new or reconstructed barrier a dock may sit up to 12 inches above the maximum elevation allowed. On an existing structure, up to 12 inches above that structure's top. ULDR 47-19.3(f).                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DISCLOSURE WHEN YOU SELL               | Contracts executed after 23 March 2023 for property in a tidally influenced area must carry a tidal flood barrier disclosure in capitalised bold-faced type of at least 14 point. ULDR 47-19.13.E.                                                                                                                                                                        |
| WHERE IT DOES NOT APPLY                | Oceanfront beaches and shorelines seaward of the Coastal Construction Control Line. ULDR 47-19.13.B.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| PERMITS                                | Development Services, through the LauderBuild portal. Signed and sealed plans for the seawall and piles by a Florida licensed engineer or architect, a special inspector form for pile installation, and dredge approval from Broward County and/or FDEP. The single-family engineering permit fee is \$244, adjusted annually for CPI without a hearing. Code Sec. 9-54. |

**Where this comes from:** City of Fort Lauderdale ULDR Sec. 47-19.13, Resiliency Standards for Tidal Flood Protection (Ord. C-23-05, 23 March 2023) and Sec. 47-19.3(f); Code of Ordinances Secs. 1-6, 2-155 and 9-54; Broward County Code Ch. 39, Art. XXV, Sec. 39-407

**Verified:** 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

## Before you call a contractor

### 1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

### 2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

### 3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

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### **Ask about building higher now**

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.